

Rare Rain Brings Colorful Wildflowers to Chile's Atacama Desert

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Colorful wildflowers are blooming across Chile's Atacama Desert after rare rain linked to this year's exceptionally strong El Niño. The bloom, described in a report published on October 2, 2026, has spread across hillsides and plains in one of the driest places on Earth.

The rain has awakened millions of seeds and **bulbs** that can stay underground for years. These resting seeds and **bulbs** can begin growing when enough **moisture** arrives. Areas that usually have little visible plant life are now covered with purple, pink, white, red and yellow flowers.

In Chile, this event is known as "**desierto florido**," which means "flowering desert." Jorge Carabantes, head of the Protected Areas Department at Chile's National Forest Corp., known as CONAF, told The Associated Press that the event includes more than 200 **plant species**. He described this desert flowering as unusual and different from blooms elsewhere in the world.

The Atacama typically receives just 0.6 inches, or 15 millimeters, of rain each year. Between July and August this year, several Chilean regions received record rainfall. Carabantes said some areas received more than 190 millimeters, with rainfall levels in some regions not seen since the 1950s. These figures describe rainfall in several Chilean regions, rather than a single measurement for the whole desert.

The flowers now cover about 6,560 square miles, or 17,000 square kilometers, of the Atacama. CONAF representatives told The Associated Press that this is the desert's most **extensive** bloom since 1997.

Tourists and photographers have visited to see the bright flowers against the mountains. Photographs also show cacti among the wildflowers and purple blossoms stretching across the plains.

The display will not last all year. By the end of spring in the **Southern Hemisphere**, many flowers will disappear. They will leave behind seeds and **bulbs** that can wait underground for another period of unusually heavy rain.

Word Treasure

moisture -- Water that allows the resting seeds and bulbs to begin growing.

bulbs -- Underground plant parts that can remain resting until enough moisture arrives.

desierto florido -- The Chilean name for the event, meaning "flowering desert."

plant species -- Different kinds of plants.

extensive -- Covering a large area.

Southern Hemisphere -- The southern half of Earth.

Break it down

Lead: Introduces the colorful bloom, its link to rare rain and El Niño, and the report's publication date.

Natural process: Explains how moisture awakens seeds and bulbs that can remain underground for years.

Expert attribution: Gives the local name and Carabantes's description of the bloom's plant diversity.

Rainfall context: Compares typical annual rainfall with recent regional records and clarifies the measurements' geographic limits.

Extent: Gives the area covered and attributes the comparison with blooms since 1997 to CONAF representatives.

Observation: Describes visitors and photographs of flowers, mountains and cacti.

Conclusion: Explains the seasonal end of the display and the seeds and bulbs left for future rain.

Why it matters

The event illustrates how unusual rainfall can awaken resting desert plants across a large area. The article also distinguishes regional rainfall measurements from a measurement for the entire desert.

Test what you remember

1. When was the report describing the bloom published?

- ☐ (A) July 2, 2026
- ☐ (B) October 2, 2026
- ☐ (C) August 2, 2026
- ☐ (D) October 2, 1997

2. What is the rare rain linked to in the article?

- ☐ (A) This year's exceptionally strong El Niño
- ☐ (B) Melting mountain snow
- ☐ (C) A change caused by visiting photographers
- ☐ (D) Water released from underground bulbs

3. How much rain does the Atacama typically receive each year?

- ☐ (A) 200 millimeters
- ☐ (B) More than 190 millimeters
- ☐ (C) 0.6 inches, or 15 millimeters
- ☐ (D) 6,560 inches

4. What does the article clarify about the unusually high rainfall figures?

- ☐ (A) They measure rainfall only in 1997.
- ☐ (B) They describe several Chilean regions, rather than one measurement for the whole desert.
- ☐ (C) They apply equally to every part of the Atacama.
- ☐ (D) They count plant species.

5. According to CONAF representatives, what makes this bloom stand out?

- ☐ (A) It is the desert's most extensive bloom since 1997.
- ☐ (B) It is the desert's first recorded bloom.
- ☐ (C) It includes only purple flowers.
- ☐ (D) It will continue throughout the year.

6. When will many of the flowers disappear?

- ☐ (A) By the end of spring in the Southern Hemisphere
- ☐ (B) At the start of 1997
- ☐ (C) Only after every underground seed has grown
- ☐ (D) Before the July rainfall

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: C 4: B 5: A 6: A

Questions to think about

1. **Jorge Carabantes:** He describes the desert flowering as unusual and different from blooms elsewhere, identifies more than 200 plant species, and reports exceptionally high rainfall in some areas.
2. **CONAF representatives:** They describe the bloom as the Atacama's most extensive since 1997.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):